

Network Security: An Exciting Challenge for Modern-Day IT Admins

Please throw some light on the latest trends in network security.

The BYOD practice poses one of the major threats for IT managers. Can you share what solutions you offer to deal with this?



Sajjan Paul, director, Systems Engineering, India & SAARC, Juniper Networks

The kind of attacks happening in the IT world today have changed considerably. Two years back, typically, one would have anti-virus software, a firewall, IDS/IPS with a static signature and static policy. But things have evolved quite a bit because a lot of companies have moved from proprietary applications or distributed applications to a centralised application system. In the case of Web-based client entities, earlier there were thick applications but now they have moved to thin applications. The attackers' profiles and attack vectors have changed. From simple malware attacks, things have moved to an Advanced Persistent Threat. This is a slow and persistent attack, involving human interventions and the use of social media.

For dealing with security issues related to BYOD, we do a kind of device tagging, which means that we know the profile of the device. Based on what OS the device runs, we have certain backend intelligence regarding the kind of heatmap that should be drawn about the OS' security level. We profile the users on that basis and apply solutions. After this comes the authentication of the user. We check whether a particular user's profile is eligible for a certain type of message, application or solution. Based on that, we apply policies. So, the first level of protection is always established and IT team has enough control.



Divakar Dayal, lead, Security, Borderless Network Sales, Cisco India & SAARC

The evolution of threats and the responses to them have changed over a period of time, whether it is a network-based response or one that is application-based. They are primarily driven by the two major trends of consumerisation and virtualisation. These two trends have exploded, creating a chaotic world where things like enterprise mobility are being driven by the social media, by phenomena like telepresence and video conferencing, and by the whole virtualisation wave. This is changing the way the threats will be tackled in the future. The BYOD trend is a new challenge that is forcing IT admins to work on ensuring fool-proof network security.

BYOD is one of the most important trends affecting IT managers. It is resulting in a lot of movement of the physical computer architecture, which is unlike what we have known as the central architecture or central control system—we are moving to a non-controlled system. The phenomenon called the cloud is enabling BYOD. Gone are the days when a controlled environment meant physical control over the devices. We are moving to a phase where 'app'ification has come in. Today, the IT admin has to control the device the end-user is using. The scenario has evolved and IT admins clearly have different challenges with BYOD coming in.



Srikanth Vissamsetti, VP, Network Security at McAfee India

Things change constantly when it comes to security. In the last two years, advanced malware with targeted attacks have become popular. These attacks are very evasive because they try to focus on one enterprise. So detecting them requires much smarter detection methods. While in the case of generic attacks, attackers aim to reach as many users as possible but in these cases, the damage is much more and IT admins have to come up with different solutions for these targeted attacks. One of the popular forms of attack these days is through social networking. One can launch threats against users by posting malicious links, launching malicious files, et al.

A lot of enterprises these days are going the Bring Your Own Device way with their employees. BYOD is leading to IT losing control over the end points. Those who bring their own devices to office can at any time install a threat, unknowingly, which is like giving malware free access to your enterprise. IT admins are no more wary of this trend. There are solutions which offer IT admins control even in this situation. Just by installing one application on the users' devices and by giving them controlled access to data, IT admins can ensure security.